The five centuries of dominance in north-central India by the Delhi Sultanate and Mughal Emperors saw intensified Indian interactions with the Islamicate world—a region stretching from Spain and Morocco to Southeast Asia—where Islam was an influential, if not always the dominant, religion. With its large population and considerable wealth, India was at the centre of the exchange of goods and people within this system, until the arrival of Europeans as missionaries, merchants, diplomats, and soldiers of fortune. In addition to goods and people, there was a vibrant exchange of ideas. For example, the Islamic world saw debates on whether religious, executive, and judicial authority should be derived from Caliphs or directly through kingly right. Among those arguing for the latter was the Spanish-born Abu Bakr al-Turtushi in his 1122 tract *Sirajulmuluk*, where he references among others the Indian author Shanaq (Chanakya). [43]

One remarkable aspect of international exchange during the era of Mughal supremacy in the subcontinent involved Africa. Starting in the fifteenth century, Indian cotton and textiles were traded with the East African coast and Ethiopia for gold, ivory, and slaves. These Habshi slaves (the term referred originally to Abyssinians but was, along with Siddi, used for Africans more broadly) were removed from their families, converted to Islam and sometimes given military training. Many found their way to the Deccan in India. One such Ethiopian-born slave, Malik Ambar, rose to become *peshwa* and army commander to the Sultan of Ahmednagar. His army of 50,000 included 10,000 Africans as well as large numbers of Maratha cavalry, and they harassed the armies and supply lines of the Mughal Empire. Such was Ambar's reputation that he appears in a 1616 painting as a severed head being shot by a bow-wielding Emperor Jehangir perched astride the world. [44]

The medieval and early modern period therefore witnessed direct and indirect Indian material contacts with an astonishingly broad geographical expanse, ranging from North Africa and the Mediterranean to Central Asia and Tibet, the South China Sea to Southeast Asia and across the Indian Ocean to East Africa. These preceded colonial-era networks that both disrupted and accelerated India's international links. For example, to the